

# The Three Conversations

**Context:** You're declining equity/partnership offers from people you like, while keeping the working relationships intact. The principle running through all three: *right relationship, wrong structure*.

**Order matters.** Talk to the hostess first (she's the easiest yes and your most valuable contributor). Then the DJ (cleanest — pure vendor relationship). Then your friend the husband (hardest, but easier once the wife conversation has gone well).

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## CONVERSATION 1 — THE HOSTESS

She's the most valuable of the three to you. She's also the most likely to accept a clean structure because she's the one actually doing skilled work that deserves real pay.

### Version A — In Person or Phone Call (Preferred)

"Hey [Name], I want to talk through how to bring you into SparkDate, because I've been thinking about it a lot since the event.

First — what you did at that event was the real thing. The name tags, the introductions, reading the room, knowing when to step in and when to step back. That's not a learnable-in-a-week skill. That's craft.

Here's where I've landed, and I want to be honest with you about my reasoning: I'm running SparkDate as a sole founder. I'm not bringing on co-founders or giving equity to anyone right now — not because of you specifically, but because I haven't even run my first event yet. I don't know what the company is going to need in 12 months, and I'd rather not lock in equity decisions before I know what the actual roles look like.

What I do want is to bring you on as our **lead hostess** at \$300 per event. That's premium — about double what most event hostesses in Philly get — because I want to pay for the level of work you actually deliver, not the market average for someone less skilled.

Here's the bigger picture: if we run 20-30 events together over the next 6 months and you crush it the way you did the other night, I want to talk about you joining as **Head of Events** with real comp and real equity tied to a real role. But that conversation makes sense after we've worked together, not before. Right now, neither of us knows what the right number is — and locking that in today would probably be wrong for both of us.

Does that work for you?"

**If she says yes:** Great. Confirm in writing the same day (see Version B below as the follow-up email).

**If she pushes back on equity:** Listen carefully. If the pushback is about wanting upside, you can offer: > "If your worry is upside — I get that. What I can do is this: if and when SparkDate raises a real round, anyone who's done meaningful work with us pre-funding gets some recognition in that round. Not equity now, but a fair conversation then. I won't forget who showed up early."

**If she says no:** That's information. It means she wanted ownership specifically, not the work. Thank her, wish her well, move on. Don't try to save the deal. Anyone who would only work with you if they own part of you isn't the right person.

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## Version B — Written Follow-Up Email (Send Same Day)

**Subject:** Confirming our conversation — SparkDate lead hostess

Hi [Name],

Great talking just now. Putting this in writing so we're aligned:

**Role:** Lead Hostess for SparkDate events **Rate:** \$300 per event (4-hour engagement, includes ~30 min pre-event setup) **Scope:** Check-in, name tags, attendee facilitation, introductions, on-the-floor problem solving, light closing duties **Schedule:** Per-event basis. I'll send dates as far in advance as possible — typically 2-3 weeks notice. **Independent contractor:** You're booking individual events as a contractor (1099). No employment relationship, no exclusivity. You're free to host other events. **Future:** If we run 20+ events together and the company takes off, we'll revisit a more formal Head of Events role with comp and equity at that point.

First event is [date] at [venue]. I'll send the run-of-show by [date - 3 days].

Excited to build this with you.

[Your Name]

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## CONVERSATION 2 — THE DJ

This one is the cleanest because it's a pure vendor relationship. DJs are booked. They are not partners. Treating him like a vendor isn't a snub — it's how every event business in the world treats DJs.

### Version A — Text or DM

"Hey [Name] — wanted to circle back on SparkDate. I'd love to have you on the rotation for our events.

Here's how I'm structuring vendors: per-event booking rate, no equity, no partnership. That's a clean line I'm holding for every vendor — if I do it for one, I have to do it for everyone, and that gets messy fast for fundraising later.

What I can offer: \$[300-500] per event for [4-hour] sets, you bring your own gear, we handle the venue coordination. If you're our preferred DJ for the first 6 months, we can talk about a preferred-vendor agreement with priority booking and possibly a small volume discount in exchange for first-call status.

Does that work? If yes, first event is [date] at [venue] — would love to have you on it."

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### Version B — Email (If You Need It More Formal)

**Subject:** SparkDate DJ booking — terms

Hi [Name],

Following up on our conversation about SparkDate events.

I'd like to book you for our launch events on a per-event basis.  
Quick details:

**Rate:** \$[400] per event (typically 4-hour set, 7:00-11:00 PM)

**Equipment:** You bring your own (we'll confirm venue power and space ahead of each event) **Booking:** Per-event basis, typically confirmed 2-3 weeks ahead **Payment:** 50% on confirmation, 50% within 48 hours of event end

A note on partnership/equity: I'm running SparkDate as a sole-founder, contractor-based model. Vendors are booked, not partnered. This isn't personal — it's how I'm keeping the cap table clean for our first fundraiser. After 6 months and 10+ events together, I'm open to a preferred-vendor arrangement with priority booking, but equity isn't on the table for any vendor.

If that works for you, first booking is [date] at [venue]. Reply to lock it in.

Best, [Your Name]

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## CONVERSATION 3 — THE HUSBAND (YOUR FRIEND)

This is the hardest because there are two relationships at stake: yours with him, and his with his wife. Done well, this conversation actually *strengthens* the friendship because it shows you respect him enough to be direct.

**Critical:** Have this conversation **after** you've talked to the hostess. If she's already excited about the lead hostess role, the partnership pressure dissipates naturally. The husband often goes along with his wife's enthusiasm.

**Even more critical:** Have this conversation **in person**, not over text. He suggested partnership as a friend. Declining as a friend, in person, with eye contact, is the only way to do it without it festering.

### Version A — In Person (Preferred — Coffee, Drink, or Walk)

"Hey, I wanted to talk to you about what you mentioned the other night — about all of us forming some kind of partnership around SparkDate. I've been thinking about it for a few days and I want to be straight with you, because I respect you too much to give you a wishy-washy answer.

I'm going to run SparkDate as a sole founder. I'm not forming a partnership.

Here's why — and I want to be clear this isn't about you, it's about structure. Three or four-person partnerships, formed before anyone has done meaningful work, before roles are defined, before money is on the line — those don't survive contact with reality. Every advisor I've talked to and every founder story I've read says the same thing: when partnerships form for *relationship* reasons rather than *business* reasons, they end ugly. And when they end ugly, the friendships don't survive either. I'd rather have you as a friend in 5 years than as a co-founder I don't speak to anymore.

What I'd love is this: [his wife's name] is coming on as our lead hostess — paid well, real role. If there's a specific operational thing you want to be involved in — running point on a venue, helping me think through a problem, plugging in your network for a specific ask — I'll come to you and pay you for it. If down the road there's an actual operational role that makes sense, we'll have that conversation with clear eyes about what it is and what it's worth.

But I'm not going to commit to a partnership today that we'd both regret in a year. I hope that makes sense — and I really hope you can hear it the way I mean it."

## How He Might React

**Best case:** *"Yeah man, I get it. That's fair. We just wanted to support you."* → Perfect. Hug it out. Move on. Don't over-explain. Don't apologize. Trust that the conversation went well.

**Pushback case:** *"But we want to be more involved than that. We're your friends. We could really help."* → Stay calm. *"And you are helping. [Wife] is going to be the most important person at our first 10 events. That's not a small role — that's a critical role. I'm not minimizing that. What I'm saying is: equity and partnership are different from involvement. You can be deeply involved without owning equity. That's how every great early team starts."*

**Difficult case:** *"This feels like you don't trust us."* → This is the one to not flinch on. *"It's not about trust. It's about structure. I'd say no to my brother in this exact same situation. Equity isn't a measure of how I feel about you — it's a tool, and tools have to be used right or they break things. I'd rather use it right than use it because it feels nice."*

**Worst case:** *"Then maybe [wife] shouldn't do the hostess thing either."* → *"That's [wife]'s call, not yours. If she wants the role, I want her in it. If she doesn't, I'll respect that. But I'm not going to negotiate her involvement through you, and you'd be putting her in a really weird spot to ask her to back out of paid work because you didn't get what you wanted in a separate conversation."* This is hard but necessary. If he tries to use his wife's participation as leverage, that's the moment to be firmest. Quiet firmness, not aggression.

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## Version B — Written Backup (Only If In-Person Goes Sideways)

Send this if he doesn't accept the in-person answer and you need a written record so the conversation doesn't keep getting re-litigated.

**Subject:** Following up on our conversation

Hey [Name],

I've been thinking about our conversation since we talked. I wanted to put my thinking in writing so it doesn't keep coming up, and so we both have something to point back to.

I'm going to run SparkDate as a sole founder. No partnership, no co-founders, no equity grants for undefined roles. This is a structural decision, not a personal one. Every investor I'll eventually need to raise from will ask about my cap table, and the only answer that holds up is "founder + contractors + advisors with defined roles."

[Wife]'s lead hostess role stands and I'm excited to have her on it.

If there's a specific operational role you want — something concrete, with a defined scope and a defined deliverable — I'll always listen, and I'll always pay fairly for the work. But I'm not going to retrofit a partnership around a vague desire to be involved.

I want our friendship to outlast SparkDate, whether SparkDate succeeds or fails. The structure I'm choosing is the one most likely to make that happen.

[Your Name]

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## ONE LAST THING — IF THE HOSTESS BACKS OUT BECAUSE OF THE HUSBAND

This is the scenario you most need to be ready for: husband doesn't get partnership, hostess pulls out of lead hostess role in solidarity.

If that happens — let her go.

It will sting. You'll be tempted to chase, renegotiate, find a way.

**Don't.** Here's why:

1. If she's making her career decisions based on her husband's emotional reactions, she was always going to be a complicated hire.
2. If a working relationship can be broken before Event #1 by an equity disagreement that doesn't even involve her directly, it would have broken at Event #5 over something else.
3. There are other excellent hostesses in Philadelphia. You can find one in 2 weeks. The cost of finding a new hostess is *much* lower than the cost of a complicated cap table or an unstable team.

**Your script if this happens:**

"I totally understand. No hard feelings — I respect that you and [husband] make decisions together. The lead hostess role will still be open for a few weeks if you change your mind. Either way, please come to our first event as a guest on the house. I'd love to have you there."

That's it. Don't beg. Don't renegotiate. Don't offer equity to win her back. Move on, find another hostess, run the event.

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## Tactical Notes

**Timing:** - Talk to hostess first (best chance of clean yes, sets the tone) - Talk to DJ second (cleanest conversation, builds momentum) - Talk to husband third, in person, ideally after wife has accepted (lowest pressure)

**Don't:** - Have all three conversations on the same day - Have any of them after drinks - Send these as form emails without personalizing - Apologize for your decision (you're not doing anything wrong) - Negotiate against yourself by sweetening the offer if they push back

**Do:** - Practice the words out loud before each conversation - Have the next thing scheduled (so the conversation has a natural end) - Document agreements in writing the same day - Trust your gut — if anyone reacts badly, take that as information about whether this person should be on your team at all

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## The Underlying Principle

These conversations are not about being tough. They're about being *clear*. Clarity is generous. Ambiguity is what destroys friendships and businesses. Every conversation above is short because clarity doesn't need a lot of words.

Have the conversations. Have them this week. Then go run Event #1.